



STARRY FACEOFF

JHALAK DIKHHLA JAA 2: Negi accused choreographer Shiamak Datar of being unfair and persuading audiences to vote for Sandhya Mridul.

NACH BALIYE 3: Shortly after the winners were declared, Rakhi Sawant claimed that the channel had hinted she and Abhishek wouldn't win the trophy. She also alleged her voting lines were closed before time.

JJHOOM INDIA: Suresh Wadkar and partner Shweta Tiwari had a public war of words when the singer refused to be part of the wild card entry round as he didn't want to be humiliated again because Tiwari was a "horrible" singer.



ALL IN THE FAMILY: The contestants of *Jhalak Dikhhla Jaa 2*

Synergy Adlabs that produced *Jhalak...2* says all eliminated contestants were in contention for the wild card. "In keeping with the scoring system, the average judges' score and average vote of each contestant was tallied and the top two on the list were put to vote." But Sudha Chandran, who was picked for the wild card round, says she was thrust in to the re-match much against her wishes. Contestants like Mir Ranjan Negi, a crowd favourite, expressed discontent over the wild card phenomenon, "we were not happy that the wild card entry was only for Sudha Chandran and Prachi Desai".

Much-publicised ousters and re-entries, bickering judges and controversial conflagrations—reality shows are increasingly looking like orchestrated extensions of daily soaps contrived by television channels to keep TRPs afloat. In Desai's case it was clear that the international format of the show, owned by BBC Worldwide, was changed to include a wild card round. While many allege that Desai's mentor Ekta Kapoor had a huge role to play in her controversial comeback, Basu claims that Sony, BBC Worldwide and Synergy were in complete agreement with him.

Ask the contestants and they will tell all; some unabashedly and some anonymously for fear of their television careers. These celebrities allege that

far from being the poor cousin of *saas-bahu* sagas, these shows revel in trumped up controversies and adversely-edited dialogues. Bedi says her quotes were used out of context on various occasions and her altercation with judges Isha Koppikar and Vaibhavi Merchant, pertaining to unjust scores, was turned into a Pooja versus Rakhi affair. Another actor, on condition of anonymity, supports this. "When we asked which couple we liked the most, we said Karan and Kavita. But in the final version our bytes were used with the question, 'Which couple are you most scared of?'"

Powerful performer Mehta, who was ousted in the very first

episode of *Jjhoom India*, also says that celebrities are constantly pursued by cameras and asked "extremely provocative" questions to catch them off-guard and wrestle some headline-grabbing quote from them. Prem Kamath, vice-president, marketing and communication, Star Plus, says, "the channel is only responsible to the extent of bringing two volatile celebrities who have some history, like Kashmira and Rakhi together. At the end of the day it's entertainment."

Bedi recounts how despite her performance receiving accolades like "superb, fantastic" she got a meagre seven from all the judges, while Sawant, whose performance was rated by Merchant as "down, up, down, down, plateau" still managed to poll nine points from each of the judges. "The marks were awarded after Rakhi revealed that her mother was unwell and a pre-shot sequence of her mother was strategically aired to win sympathy," alleges Bedi.

Such publicity stunts are putting many celebrities off the reality format. While Chandran refuses to ever be a part of a reality show again, "not even if I am in a dire state of poverty", Bedi insists she will insert clauses in her contract that she won't be misquoted and demand to know who the judges are in advance. Soap star Shweta Keswani, also a contestant on *Nach Baliye 3*, asserts, "No more reality shows for me, ever." That's the reality of our times. ■